IT IS FASCINATING WHEN BOTH VIVAN SUNDARAM AND TAPAN BHATTACHARYA ARE WORKING WITH DIFFERENT FORMS BUT THEIR IDEAS ECHO AND SPEAK TO ONE ANOTHER



FORMS TO PONDER ON Left, 'Large Object' by Vivan Sundaram; top left, 'False Totality' by Tapan Bhattacharya

"suspended in an amniotic stupor, almost unwilling to be born". It is an apt description, as the human-creatures in Bhattacharya's paintings distinctly lack facial hair and emanate a curious adolescent look.

Bhattacharya continues, "At other times they seem afloat in a forgotten dream that never trails off. Having broken free of remembered forms, they shadow a dismembered world pieced together with the remains of visual habits and aesthetic traditions." His painting 'False Totality', for instance, is a strange take on a party situation where each person is turned into dreamlike totems, resembling worms or clouds.

Vivan Sundaram's biology-class sculptures are from his 2013 exhibition *Postmortem*. Sundaram happened to be Bhattacharya's mentor, starting from 1997, when both worked on a massive installation project inside the Victoria Memorial in Kolkata. The duo became lifelong friends and Sundaram was instrumental in supporting Bhattacharya's idiosyncratic watercolours and gouaches.

This exhibition was curated by Sundaram's wife, art critic and historian Geeta Kapur. Indeed, it's fascinating when both artists are working with different forms but their ideas echo and speak to one another. One Bhattacharya painting has a skull in the womb of a pregnant woman, while Sundaram's sculptures include reconstructions of the skeletal jawline. Who or what is human, after all? ■

—Devarsi Ghosh

The exhibition runs till Oct. 31

ART ▼

Monumental Milestones

Art Alive Gallery marks 25 years with specially commissioned works spanning generations of Indian art



GRAND BANQUET Jayasri Burman's tableau 'Naivedya Nivedan' (oil on canvas, 2026)

Seminal works by 30 artists across generations—including modernists such as S.H. Raza, Krishen Khanna and Satish Gujral, alongside artists such as Sakti Burman, Manu and Madhvi Parekh, K. Laxma Goud, Thota Vaikuntam, Jogen Chowdhury and Anjolie Ela Menon, among others—mark the 25th anniversary of Art Alive Gallery in an exhibition titled *A Moment in the Monumental*.

"Almost the entire exhibition consists of works that were specially commissioned for it and involved conversations and interactions that were enriching for me and played on the gallery's heritage of leaving a legacy for all times to come," says curator Kishore Singh.

Some of the highlights include Sakti Burman's sculpture titled 'The Upward Path', Jayasri Burman's 'Naivedya Nivedan', a tableau in which the artist invites 36 figures to a banquet she personally serves; Paresh Maity's 40-feet painting 'Arunouday', depicting Srinagar's horizon before sunrise; Veer Munshi's 'Maeras (Legacy)', a Kashmir-themed relief painting that draws upon his experience as a displaced Kashmiri Pandit, and new works by Amrit Kaur and Rabindra Kaur, known collectively as The Singh Twins.

HIGHLIGHTS INCLUDE **SAKTI BURMAN'S 'THE UPWARD PATH'**, VEER MUNSHI'S 'MAERAS' AND PARESH MAITY'S 'ARUNOUDAY'

"There's nothing predictable about either the works or the exhibition," says Singh, who wanted to establish a continuity while considering growth, changes, assimilations and disruptions that have shaped the making of art. "*A Moment in the Monumental* is both a commemoration as well as a celebration of Indian art across all its diversities," he says. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

The exhibition is at Bikaner House from Sept. 26-Oct. 6 and at Art Alive Gallery from Oct. 15-Nov. 15